

HIGH SCHOOLS

BOYS DISTRICT BASKETBALL

Tigers stay hot, hold off Panthers for ninth straight win

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

As he was unlacing his basketball shoes, Cleveland Heights' Barry Cofield spoke about the sign he and his teammates now carry with them to every game.

"It reads 'T.E.A.M.,'" said Cofield. "Together, everyone achieves more."

And last night, no one achieved more than Cofield.

The Tigers, with Cofield dominating the boards and scoring several clutch baskets inside, turned back Euclid, 64-56, in a boys Division I district semifinal game at Cleveland South.

DIVISION I	
CLEVELAND HEIGHTS	64
EUCLID	56

Cleveland Heights (16-6), unseeded at South, will take a nine-game winning streak into Saturday's district finals. The Tigers, who won five district championships at South during the 1990s, will face the winner of tonight's semifinal matchup between Brush (18-3) and Shaker Heights (14-7). Tip-off Saturday will be 1:30 p.m.

"Barry is so strong and so smart, he just killed us all night," said Euclid coach Sean O'Toole.

"He knows the other players on his team so well and he positions himself perfectly. He has a nice touch, and you can't move him."

Second-seeded Euclid (14-8) rode the scoring of senior forward Chris Harrell to an early lead. After Harrell completed a three-point play, the Panthers led, 19-13, with 5:46 remaining in the first half. Harrell, who is bound for Penn State on a football scholarship, scored 13 of his game-high 22 points in the first 16 minutes.

After a three-point play by senior guard Todd Sparrow, Euclid led, 26-21, with 1:48 left in the

half. But, after a steal and a driving one-hander high off the glass by senior forward Aaron Nixon, Cleveland Heights trailed, 26-23, at halftime.

"We just had to turn it up and get back to playing like a team," said Cofield, who tied Nixon for team honors with 19 points. "I'm sort of a garbage man. I just try to pick up what the other guys leave behind."

A 6-4, 230-pound junior, Cofield cleaned up in the second half as he repeatedly hurt the Panthers with backside rebounding and putbacks.

Cleveland Heights, which split

its two Lake Erie League matchups with Euclid this season, moved to a 39-31 lead on an offensive rebound by Cofield and a strong move inside by Nixon with 3:22 left in the third quarter. The Tigers extended their advantage to 44-33 on a 3-pointer by senior forward James Lewis and a follow by Cofield, and led, 46-35, after Lewis beat the third-quarter buzzer with a breakaway layup.

"The third quarter has been our downfall all season," O'Toole said. "I better go to a clinic this summer on halftime talks."

O'Toole's Panthers had a couple of runs left.

Sparked by a three-point play by junior center Andrew Fairman and a 3-pointer by senior guard Tony Basalla, Euclid closed to 46-41 with 7:06 left. After two free throws by Harrell with 2:22 to go, the Panthers trailed, 53-49.

But Cleveland Heights had the answer each time. Nixon's baseline jumper and Cofield's three-point play offset the first run, and Nixon's strong post-up move, two free throws by senior point guard Roger McClinton and a layup by Cofield helped thwart Euclid's late bid.

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BOYS DISTRICT BASKETBALL

Buzzer-beater is a great painkiller

By BRANSON WRIGHT
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Allen Kirkpatrick had visions of this day ever since he started shooting baskets at the park. He never dreamed this would be his time to deliver, especially because of the pain in his shooting wrist. But for three seconds, all of that was forgotten.

Kirkpatrick floated through the middle of the lane and shot a knuckleball that swished through the nets at the buzzer to give Lutheran East a thrilling 50-48 victory yesterday over Lorain Catholic in the Division IV district semifinals at Strongsville High School.

Lutheran East (18-4) will face Central Christian at 7 p.m. tomorrow in the district championship. Central Christian advanced following its semifinal victory over Dalton.

Kirkpatrick's heroics were set up when Lorain Catholic turned the ball over with 14 seconds left. The Falcons ran the clock down to 3.3 seconds and called a timeout.

"We were running the play to either Carlton [Dean] or to Allen," Lutheran East coach Ron Carlson said. "I told them that this is money time. I didn't want overtime because [Lorain Catholic] had the momentum. We had stopped playing."

So had Kirkpatrick, who scored 13 of his 16 points during the first half. It was time for him to get the job done.

Kirkpatrick received the pass at the top of the key. He made his move and took a dribble through the middle of the lane. Kirkpatrick jumped and floated in the air as he released the shot.

"I knew I had to take it," Kirkpatrick said. "The defense played me to the right and I'm left-handed. When I shot it, I thought it was an airball."

The ball was briefly airborne before falling over the rim and straight through the net at the buzzer. Falcons players and fans swarmed Kirkpatrick.

DIVISION IV	
LUTHERAN EAST	50
LORAIN CATHOLIC	48

"Those are shots you dream about and that was the first time in my life that I've ever won a game at the buzzer," Kirkpatrick said. "And I'm glad that this game was postponed from Tuesday because of the weather. I hurt my wrist two weeks ago, and it was so sore, that I wouldn't have been able to play."

Kirkpatrick's play during the first half helped the Falcons to a 34-20 lead, but the Spartans came back during the second half. The Spartans found holes in the Falcons zone during the first half, but the shots weren't falling.

That wasn't the case in the second half as the shots started to fall. Brandon Bass' bucket extended the Falcons' lead to 16. Dan Ksiakz, who finished with 15 points, ignited the Spartans cause with a 3-pointer. Chris Dalton followed with a 3-pointer, plus he was fouled and his free throw completed a four-point play.

The Spartans continued to chip away until they trailed, 46-37, with 4:06 left. The Spartans went into another scoring funk and Lutheran East led, 43-37, at the end of the quarter.

Lutheran East led, 46-40, in the fourth when Nate Mezlak began to attack the basket. Mezlak scored on a layup and split a pair of free throws and the Spartans trailed by three. The Spartans tied the score behind a 3-pointer. Lutheran East regained the lead on a putback, but Mezlak's two free throws tied the score at 48 with 2:13 left. But it was the Falcons who came through at the end.

"This win is great for us," Kirkpatrick said. "We have nine seniors on the team and we've been together since we were freshmen. We've been waiting for this for a long time."

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REGINA

FROM 1-D

Burgess sizzles as Royals romp

Six consecutive points in the first three minutes of the second quarter extended Regina's lead to 29-11.

Moore's 10-foot jumper and length-of-the-court bucket off a steal led to a 33-16 lead at intermission.

While it was Moore who did most of the damage in the second half with 16 points, junior Sarah Burgess was outstanding in the first half. The junior point guard scored all of her 18 points by halftime, connecting on 8 of 9 from the field, including two 3-pointers.

What excited Royals coach Pat Diulus was the way his team reacted after the Vikings, ranked No. 6 in the area and No. 5 in the state, scored the first two baskets of the game.

"The experience Sarah and Ari have in big games was evident," said Diulus. "After [VASJ] took the lead, they settled the other girls down by telling them it was only two baskets."

"The other players fed off that."

BOYS DISTRICT BASKETBALL

Mogadore gets past Kirtland

FROM STAFF REPORTS

Mogadore overcame a six-point halftime deficit to defeat Kirtland, 56-43, in a Division IV district semifinal at Cardinal last night.

The unseeded Wildcats (15-8) advance to the district final tomorrow against No. 4 seed Badger.

Mogadore outscored Kirtland, 15-6, in the third quarter to take a

three-point lead.

Jon Raddish led the Wildcats with 21 points. He was 10 of 13 from the line and had nine rebounds. Eric Rosak scored 11.

Center C.J. Trivisonno's 14 points and seven rebounds led Kirtland. Guard Ryan Russ had 13 points, including three 3-pointers. The Hornets, who won the Chagrin Valley Conference's Chagrin Division, finished 13-10.

Streaks snapped

Magnificat falls just short to Lady Irish

By DICK ZUNT
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

ASHLAND — Magnificat's string of narrow victories ended last night with a 49-48 loss to Toledo Central Catholic in Kates Gymnasium of Ashland University.

"We've won a number of close games recently, but tonight it just caught up with us," said Magnificat coach Dick Deasy, who has had the Blue Streaks in regional play in each of his four seasons as head coach.

"We fought to the end," said senior Mary Fox, who will attend Iowa State on a basketball scholarship. "We came out on fire for the second half and never gave up. We never stopped shooting."

It was Fox who tied the game at 45-45 with a 3-point field goal with 1:18 remaining. However, Central Catholic's Nicole Brown slipped underneath for a layup 14 seconds later.

DIVISION I

Tiffany Dougherty converted two free throws for the Lady Irish with 20.9 remaining for a 49-45 lead, but Magnificat kept coming. Junior Emily Turza sank a 3-pointer with 3.7 seconds showing and called timeout, but Central Catholic successfully ran out the clock.

The final buzzer ended Magnificat's season at 20-5. The Lady Irish (23-2) will meet Celina (22-2) in Saturday's regional title game, with the winner advancing to the Final Four of next week's state tournament.

Magnificat led, 15-11, at the end of the first quarter, but trailed, 23-22, at halftime.

The game was tied at 36 after three quarters. Junior Caitlin Hubach converted two free throws to give Magnificat its last lead, 42-41, with 2:50 left.

"We had opportunities, but they cashed in on them and we did not," said Deasy. "The kids played hard and met a lot of challenges. The number of close games just caught up with us."

"I'm so proud of all the girls on the team," said Fox, who led her team with 14 points. "All matured and grew during the season."

Central Catholic's Brown had a game-high 16 points.

Celina 69, Padua Franciscan 60 — Hitting eight 3-pointers and cashing in 21 of 25 free throws came up mighty big for the Bulldogs, who sidelined the Bruins (17-7).

Padua, with junior Emily Kocinski leading the way with a season-best 21 points, led, 14-9, at the end of the first quarter. Celina outscored the Bruins,

20-11, in the second quarter and took a 29-25 lead at halftime.

The game was tied at 42 after a running jumper in the key by Kocinski late in the third quarter, which ended with Celina leading, 54-44.

A 3-point field goal by Padua senior Liz Baylog cut the Bruins' deficit to 51-50. Padua trailed by

two points twice more, the last with 2:24 remaining, but the Bulldogs cashed in at the foul line in the closing minutes to build the final margin.

"I've got a great group of girls," said Padua coach Jake Lantz. "It's been a wonderful ride. Emily Kocinski has been a standout on defense for us. I'm

glad that she had a big game on offense. Having Liz Baylog and Dana Halicki in foul trouble hurt us."

Baylog fouled out in the fourth quarter. Sophomore Steffani Jaworski scored 11 points for the Bruins.

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BOYS DISTRICT BASKETBALL

Bulldogs run away from Green Wave

By BOB MIGRA
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Basketball is often a game of momentum.

But the second half of last night's boys Division II district semifinal game at Admiral King was more like a wave — and not a Green Wave.

Olmsted Falls broke open a close game with a 14-0 run in the third quarter, then continued to pull away in a 73-58 victory over Holy Name.

"We knew we were going to be in a ballgame," Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue said. "If you look at the way they've been playing since the middle of the season, they're a very good basketball team. We just thought it would be a matter of whether or not we could wear them down, and I think we did that."

Mike Gansey scored 11 of the

DIVISION II	
OLMSTED FALLS	73
HOLY NAME	58

Bulldogs' 14 points in the third-quarter run. His reverse scoop shot on a fast break drew coins and fans from both sides of the gym. On the next possession, a Gansey dunk off a Green Wave turnover gave the Bulldogs a 50-38 lead.

Gansey finished with 38 points, 12 rebounds, four assists and four blocked shots.

"At halftime, coach said we were up by five and we had to make one more run and shut them down and we did," Gansey said.

In the fourth quarter, the Bulldogs had their fast-break game working to perfection.

Armando Flores and Neal Saluta scored layups in rapid suc-

cession, giving Olmsted Falls a 63-42 lead.

On Saluta's layup, the Bulldogs went from half-court to the basket without a dribble. Gansey snapped a pass to Garry Reitzler, who found Saluta streaking toward the hoop from the left side.

Saluta, who finished with 14 points, took Reitzler's pass, floated under the basket, and tossed in a reverse layup.

"That's the way we like to play," Gansey said. "Fast break is our style of game. It's just fun running up and down like that."

Top-seeded Olmsted Falls (18-4) won its 12th consecutive game while advancing to Saturday's championship. The Bulldogs will play the winner of tonight's Avon Lake-Elyria Catholic semifinal game. Avon Lake beat the Bulldogs in last season's championship.

"I can't wait," Gansey said.

"Last year we lost and that's been in the back of my head ever since."

Holy Name, which defeated Villa Angela-St. Joseph and Cleveland Central Catholic in the second half of the season, finishes at 9-13.

Tom Harrington led the Green Wave with 13 points and Greg DiMarrino scored 12.

"We thought if we could get them out of their pressure defense we had a chance in this game," Green Wave coach Frank O'Brien said. "We did that in the first half. But we had some turnovers in the third quarter that hurt."

"They're a tournament-tested team and Mike Gansey is a tremendous player. He's one of the premier basketball players in the whole state."

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